What Is an MVP?

A focused product experiment—not a vision statement or a pile of features.

A Minimum Viable Product (MVP) is the smallest coherent product scope that can deliver a meaningful outcome for a defined user and help the team learn about important assumptions. It is not simply the smallest amount of software that can be built.

Three things an MVP must connect

A real user and problem

Who is the product for, in what context, and what problem or unmet need is it intended to address?

A meaningful outcome

What should the user be able to achieve, decide or experience after using the product?

A learning purpose

What important assumption should the MVP help test, and what evidence would help the team decide what to do next?

The central idea

An MVP is a deliberate boundary around the first coherent experience that can create user value and generate useful learning. “Minimum” means no unnecessary scope; “viable” means the chosen scope still works as a meaningful whole.

Not a shortcut around thinking

An MVP does not excuse a weak problem definition, an incoherent user journey or untested assumptions disguised as facts.

MVP, product vision or feature collection?

These three things can appear in the same product discussion, but they serve different purposes.

PRODUCT VISION

The desired future and broader change the product aims to create.

Longer-term direction; may include several user groups, journeys and capabilities.

FEATURE COLLECTION

A list of possible functions or ideas, often accumulated from requests or brainstorming.

Describes possible product parts, but does not by itself explain the problem, outcome, sequence or minimum coherent scope.

MVP

A deliberately bounded first product experience designed to deliver a meaningful outcome and test important assumptions.

Connects a defined user and problem to an outcome, a coherent journey, explicit scope and a learning purpose.

A practical test

If you can only name features, you probably have a feature collection. If you can describe the future you want to create, you have a vision. To define an MVP, you must also explain for whom, which problem or outcome, what coherent first experience, and what you need to learn.

Example

Vision: “Make it easier for readers to discover their next book.” Feature collection: “Search, ratings, lists, recommendations, profiles.” MVP framing: “Help a defined group of readers choose a suitable next book through one focused journey, while learning whether the recommendations are useful.” This is illustrative, not a validated product claim.

What makes an MVP viable?

A small scope is not automatically a good MVP. The scope needs to be small enough to build and learn from, but complete enough to let a user achieve the intended outcome.

Five questions to ask

1. USER	Can we identify the primary user and the situation in which the product is useful?
2. PROBLEM / OUTCOME	Is the intended user outcome meaningful and connected to a plausible problem?
3. CORE JOURNEY	Can the user complete a coherent path from starting point to outcome?
4. SCOPE BOUNDARY	Can we explain what is included, what is excluded and why?
5. LEARNING	What assumption are we testing, and what observation or metric would inform the next decision?

MVP does not mean…

- …a prototype with no clear learning purpose.
- …a product that is so stripped down that the core outcome cannot be achieved.
- …the first release of every feature anyone has requested.
- …proof that the business will succeed.
- …a promise that no further iteration will be needed.

Remember

The right MVP is defined by the learning and user outcome it enables—not by a universal feature count or a fixed number of weeks.

Quick self-check: do you have an MVP?

Use these prompts to test whether your current idea is more than a vision or a feature list. If an answer is unknown, record it as an open question rather than guessing.

MVP framing checklist

- [ ] The primary user and context are described.
- [ ] The problem or need is stated separately from the proposed solution.
- [ ] The intended user outcome is clear.
- [ ] The Core Job(s) describe what the user is trying to accomplish.
- [ ] The proposed scope supports a coherent core journey.
- [ ] Inclusions and exclusions have explicit reasons.
- [ ] The key assumption or learning question is named.
- [ ] There is a plausible way to observe whether the outcome or learning goal is achieved.

Write your current MVP hypothesis

For [user] in [context], this MVP helps them [outcome].

The most important assumption we want to test is…

The minimum coherent journey includes… / It excludes…

Key takeaway

An MVP is not the smallest feature list. It is the smallest coherent scope that can create meaningful user value and support a deliberate learning goal.